

UMBRA

STUDIO HANDBOOK

Internal Operations Manual / Revision 0.2

**WE DO NOT CREATE HORROR.
WE CREATE EVIDENCE.**

FOUNDER EDITION • 10 JULY 2026 • INTERNAL USE ONLY

ADMINISTRATION

Document Control

This handbook is the authoritative operating reference for UMBRA Studio. It defines the studio hierarchy, brand logic, visual language, production system, case-file structure, asset standards, review gates and release workflow. When an individual preference conflicts with this document, the handbook takes precedence until a formal revision is approved.

STANDARD	APPLICATION
Document ID	UMB-HBK-0001
Current revision	0.2 - Foundation System
Owner	UMBRA Studio / Founder
Working language	English
Document status	Living internal document
Applies to	All CASE files, assets, stories, products and public communications
Revision rule	Major creative decisions require a documented handbook update

AUTHORITY RULE

One universe. One archive. One production standard. No public release may contradict the handbook, the canon, or the permanent Codex.

How to Use This Handbook

Use Chapters 1-3 to judge whether an idea belongs to UMBRA.

Use Chapters 4-6 when designing images, documents, entities and locations.

Use Chapters 7-9 to build and review a CASE product.

Use Chapters 10-12 to name, package, publish and archive finished work.

When a new rule becomes necessary, add it through a versioned revision rather than relying on memory.

NAVIGATION

Contents

01	Studio Mandate	Purpose, mission, vision and operating principles
02	Brand Architecture	Hierarchy of studio, universe, archive, CASE and asset
03	Canon Framework	The Fade, narrative boundaries and truth levels
04	Visual DNA	Photography, composition, color, texture and atmosphere
05	Documentary Identity	Archive typography, stamps, labels and evidence language
06	Codex System	Permanent identifiers, metadata and relationship rules
07	CASE Architecture	Required folders, story structure and product contents
08	Production Pipeline	Idea to released archive
09	Quality Control	Creative, technical and commercial release gates
10	File and Folder Standards	Naming, versions, exports and backups
11	Commercial Packaging	Etsy, Gumroad and direct-sale product logic
12	Launch Roadmap	First 30 days and CASE-001 production plan
A	Templates	Asset card, CASE brief, review sheet and release checklist

FOUNDATION

01. Studio Mandate

Mission

CORE STATEMENT

We do not create horror. We create evidence.

UMBRA Studio creates fictional archive experiences that feel recovered rather than invented. The studio does not sell isolated AI images. It builds a coherent intellectual property through evidence collections, case files, environmental storytelling, recurring symbols, linked incidents and believable documentation.

Vision

Build an internationally recognizable archive-horror brand capable of expanding into digital products, short-form video, books, interactive investigations, games, physical collectibles and licensed creative assets without losing its internal logic or visual identity.

Creative Position

STANDARD	APPLICATION
We are	An archive-first narrative studio
We create	Recovered evidence, linked CASE files and believable anomalies
The audience becomes	An investigator, archivist or witness
Primary emotional effect	Dread produced by incomplete understanding
Long-term asset	A reusable fictional universe and permanent Codex
We are not	A random horror-art shop or trend-dependent prompt catalogue

Five Operating Values

01 Discovery over spectacle

The viewer should notice, compare and investigate.

02 Atmosphere over shock

Silence, scale and absence outlast gore.

03 Questions over answers

Mystery creates return visits and theory-building.

04 Consistency over quantity

A small coherent archive is more valuable than thousands of unrelated files.

05 Longevity over trends

Every release must still belong to UMBRA years later.

SYSTEM

02. Brand Architecture

UMBRA is organized as a strict hierarchy. Each level has a separate function. The hierarchy prevents naming confusion and makes every asset traceable from the studio level down to the individual exported file.

STANDARD	APPLICATION
UMBRA Studio	The real-world creative and commercial organization.
UMBRA Universe	The total fictional continuity and all canon material.
UMBRA Archive	The fictional institution that recovers, classifies and releases evidence.
CASE File	A complete investigation centered on one anomaly or incident.
Evidence Collection	A grouped content set within a CASE, such as CCTV or witness records.
Codex Object	A permanent entity, location, artifact, document or symbol.
Asset	An individual image, report page, map, texture, clip or promotional file.

Naming Hierarchy

Official public and internal names follow this structure:

HIERARCHY

UMBRA Studio > UMBRA Universe > UMBRA Archive > CASE-### > Evidence Collection > Codex Object > Individual Asset

Decision Ownership

STANDARD	APPLICATION
Founder / Producer	Approves business direction, release priority and

STANDARD	APPLICATION
	final publication.
Creative Direction	Protects concept, tone, canon and audience experience.
Art Direction	Protects Visual DNA, composition, realism and documentary identity.
Lore and Codex	Maintains permanent names, links, dates, classifications and contradictions.
Production	Generates, edits, exports, organizes and packages assets.
Release and SEO	Prepares listings, previews, metadata and distribution.

03. Canon Framework

The Fade

The Fade is the central condition of the UMBRA Universe. It is not a conventional disaster, disease or villain. It is the gradual loss of agreement between reality, memory, place and evidence. The Fade does not destroy the world dramatically. It removes certainty from it.

Permanent Canon Rules

No reliable source remembers when The Fade began.

Reality rarely changes instantly; it weakens, repeats, contradicts or disappears.

Ordinary environments are more important than spectacular supernatural worlds.

Evidence may conflict, but contradictions must feel purposeful rather than careless.

Entities are symptoms, adaptations or witnesses - never complete explanations.

The Archive may classify an event without fully understanding it.

Every CASE must leave at least one unresolved question.

No final origin explanation for The Fade may be published.

Truth Levels

STANDARD	APPLICATION
Level 0 - Confirmed	Facts fixed by the handbook and never contradicted.
Level 1 - Archive Accepted	The Archive treats this as reliable, but future evidence may complicate it.
Level 2 - Witness Account	Subjective testimony that may be mistaken, altered or incomplete.
Level 3 - Contested	Multiple credible records disagree.
Level 4 - Suppressed	Material known to exist but intentionally withheld or damaged.
Level 5 - Unknown	No interpretation is officially favored.

Narrative Boundaries

Avoid traditional chosen-one stories and world-saving plots.

Avoid neat scientific explanations, exposition dumps and definitive monster biographies.

Avoid parody unless a separate non-canon label is used.

Do not use real tragedies, missing persons or institutions in a way that could be mistaken for factual reporting.

All public products must be clearly presented as fictional creative works in store descriptions and license files.

04. Visual DNA

Visual Objective

PRIMARY TEST

Does the image feel discovered instead of created?

A successful UMBRA image should create doubt about its origin while remaining clearly part of a fictional product when viewed in commercial context. The image must feel physically plausible, imperfectly captured and narratively incomplete.

Preferred Image Languages

STANDARD	APPLICATION
35mm documentary photograph	Human-scale scenes, natural grain, imperfect focus and restrained contrast.
Disposable camera	Flash falloff, casual framing and accidental evidence.
CCTV	Fixed viewpoint, empty time, compression artifacts and institutional distance.
Bodycam	Urgency, partial obstruction and unstable framing.
VHS / broadcast capture	Temporal distance, tracking noise and degraded information.
Polaroid / instant photograph	Object-centered evidence with handwritten catalog context.
Scanner / photocopy	Documents, diagrams and repeated degradation.
Technical survey image	Neutral framing that becomes disturbing through content.

Color System

STANDARD	APPLICATION
Concrete Black	#161616 - titles, deep negative space and stamps
Archive Gray	#6B6B68 - metadata and secondary type
Paper Bone	#E7E3D8 - document backgrounds and aged labels
Institutional Green	#56645A - subtle uniforms, walls and classification marks
Desaturated Blue	#54616A - night exteriors, files and cold interiors
Oxide Brown	#725747 - rust, old furniture and contaminated paper
Warning Red	#7B2E2A - rare classification marks only; never decorative

Composition Rules

The anomaly should usually occupy less than 15% of the frame.

Use empty space as narrative pressure rather than filling every area.

Prefer eye-level, institutional or accidental viewpoints over cinematic hero shots.

Include one primary question and no more than three secondary clues.

Keep faces partially hidden, distant, blurred or contextually obscured when uncertainty is important.

Use practical light sources: fluorescent fixtures, street lamps, camera flash, windows and emergency lights.

Distortion must support the capture medium; do not add random glitch effects.

Forbidden Visual Shortcuts

Glowing eyes, random tentacles, generic horned demons and fantasy armor.

Excessive blood, decorative gore or shock imagery without narrative function.

Perfectly centered AI portraits presented as evidence.

Overprocessed teal-orange cinema grading.

Unreadable pseudo-text generated inside important documents.

Impossible anatomy unless the anomaly is deliberate, reviewed and narratively justified.

Heavy VHS overlays applied to every image regardless of source.

BRAND LANGUAGE

05. Documentary Identity

UMBRA must remain recognizable without relying on a logo. Recognition comes from repeated document structures, classification language, identifier placement, controlled typography, stamps, metadata blocks and consistent evidence captions.

Tone of Voice

STANDARD	APPLICATION
Archive voice	Neutral, restrained, precise and emotionally distant.
Witness voice	Human, incomplete, specific and occasionally contradictory.
Marketing voice	Atmospheric but clear about product contents and fictional nature.
Lore voice	Suggestive, economical and focused on observable consequences.
Forbidden voice	Melodramatic hype, excessive adjectives, direct explanation or meme language.

Standard Vocabulary

Use: recovered, catalogued, observed, recorded, disputed, unverified, redacted, transferred, inactive, unresolved.

Use CASE for a complete investigation and INCIDENT for an event inside a CASE.

Use ENTITY only after formal classification; earlier evidence may use subject, figure or individual.

Use ARTIFACT for a physical object with anomalous relevance.

Use RELEASE for a commercial product and DISCLOSURE for an in-universe public archive publication.

Document Layout Standard

Primary identifier in the top-left or top-right corner.

Document title and classification separated from narrative text.

Dates use ISO style internally: YYYY-MM-DD.

Times use 24-hour notation when part of evidence.

All redactions must hide meaningful information, not function as decoration.

Handwriting should appear only where a plausible person would have added it.
Every document page must remain readable at full resolution.

KNOWLEDGE MANAGEMENT

06. Codex System

The Codex is the permanent registry of the UMBRA Universe. Once an identifier is publicly released, it is never reused. Objects may be reclassified, but the original identifier and revision history remain traceable.

STANDARD	APPLICATION
UMB-LOC-###	Locations
UMB-ENT-###	Entities
UMB-ART-###	Artifacts
UMB-DOC-###	Documents and media records
UMB-SYM-###	Symbols, marks and written systems
UMB-ORG-###	Organizations and internal departments
UMB-EVT-###	Events spanning multiple CASE files
UMB-PER-###	Named persons when permanent tracking is necessary

Required Codex Metadata

☐	Permanent Codex ID and approved public name.
☐	Category and current classification status.
☐	One-sentence observable description.
☐	First recorded date and source CASE.
☐	Canon truth level.
☐	Known relationships to other Codex objects.
☐	Visual restrictions and continuity notes.
☐	Prompt version or creation method.
☐	Asset and release history.
☐	Commercial usage and license notes.

Relationship Rules

Every major Codex object should connect to at least one existing or planned object.

Connections must serve story discovery, production reuse or future product expansion.

Do not create references only to simulate depth; each teased identifier must eventually receive a purpose.

Cross-CASE clues should remain understandable even when the buyer owns only one product.

No hidden clue may require personal data, real-world trespassing or unsafe behavior to solve.

PRODUCT DESIGN

07. CASE Architecture

A CASE is the primary narrative and commercial unit of UMBRA. It must function as a complete experience while expanding the wider universe. Each CASE combines usable digital assets with a structured investigation.

Mandatory CASE Structure

STANDARD	APPLICATION
00_ADMIN	Brief, rights log, working notes and release checklist.
01_STORY	CASE summary, canon notes, timeline and clue map.
02_CODEX	All new and referenced Codex records.
03_EVIDENCE_PHOTOS	Primary photographs and contact sheets.
04_CCTV_VIDEO	Stills, clips, timestamps and source notes.
05_DOCUMENTS	Reports, interviews, notices, letters and records.
06_MAPS_PLANS	Floor plans, diagrams, routes and technical drawings.
07_AUDIO_TRANSCRIPTS	Optional audio logs, transcripts and waveform images.
08_PRODUCT	Customer-ready files, guide, license and archive package.
09_MARKETING	Listing images, video teasers, thumbnails and social copy.
10_SOURCE	Prompts, generation history, editable masters and rejected variants.

Narrative Sequence

Hook: one immediately legible contradiction or impossible detail.

Orientation: enough information to understand the place, date and investigative context.

Escalation: evidence reveals a pattern rather than simply becoming more graphic.

Cross-confirmation: at least two different evidence types point to the same anomaly.

Contradiction: one credible source challenges the Archive interpretation.

Final discovery: the CASE changes how earlier evidence is understood.

Unresolved exit: one question remains open and may connect to a future CASE.

Minimum Viable Commercial CASE

STANDARD	APPLICATION
Primary evidence	20-30 high-resolution images
Documents	6-10 readable pages
Maps or diagrams	2-4 files
Archive guide	1 customer-facing PDF
Cover and previews	6-10 marketplace images
License and readme	2 files
Story length	A complete 15-30 minute browsing experience
Reusable assets	At least 70% suitable for video, design or storytelling use

OPERATIONS

08. Production Pipeline

01. Opportunity

Define the buyer, use case, emotional promise and marketplace format.

02. CASE Brief

Write title, one-line premise, anomaly, evidence types and unresolved question.

03. Canon Check

Confirm the idea fits The Fade and does not duplicate an existing object.

04. Codex Reservation

Reserve IDs before public generation or file naming.

05. Visual Prototype

Create 3-5 test images to establish realism, palette and capture medium.

06. Evidence Plan

Build the shot list, document list, clue sequence and relationship map.

07. Production

Generate or design assets in controlled batches with version tracking.

08. Selection

Reject repetition, AI artifacts, weak clues and style drift.

09. Post-production

Repair anatomy, typography, perspective, noise and export consistency.

10. Document Assembly

Create reports, maps, captions, guide and customer navigation.

11. Quality Gates

Run creative, technical, legal and commercial review.

12. Packaging

Prepare folders, ZIP archives, license, previews and listing metadata.

13. Release

Publish, test downloads and verify customer experience.

14. Archive

Store masters, prompts, release hashes, versions and performance notes.

Batch Discipline

Generate by evidence category, not by random inspiration.

Each batch must have a written objective and rejection criteria.

Never expand a weak visual direction simply because generation is easy.

Keep approved masters separate from raw outputs and rejected material.

Record the prompt, model, edit history and final filename for every released asset.

RELEASE GATES

09. Quality Control

Creative Gate

☐	The CASE contains a clear mystery and a controlled unresolved ending.
☐	Every major asset contributes evidence, atmosphere or usability.
☐	The anomaly remains subtle enough to invite investigation.
☐	Cross-CASE references are purposeful and documented.
☐	The release expands the universe rather than repeating an earlier product.

Visual Gate

☐	No obvious generation artifacts, malformed hands, repeated objects or accidental text.
☐	Lighting, lens behavior and degradation match the claimed capture medium.
☐	Color and contrast remain within UMBRA Visual DNA.
☐	All text-bearing documents are manually typeset and readable.
☐	Preview images accurately represent the files delivered.

Technical Gate

☐	Files open correctly and use the promised dimensions and formats.
☐	No duplicate filenames, missing links or accidental source files.
☐	ZIP structure matches the customer guide.
☐	PDF documents render without clipping, broken fonts or black glyph boxes.
☐	Filename characters are platform-safe and consistent.
☐	Download package size and marketplace limits have been checked.

Commercial and Trust Gate

☐	The listing clearly states that the work is fictional and digitally created.
☐	Usage rights and restrictions are understandable.
☐	No trademarked characters, copyrighted franchises or real-person likenesses are used without rights.
☐	No real missing-person case, medical record or government document is misleadingly replicated.
☐	Customer receives exactly the content, count and formats described.

10. File and Folder Standards

Root Structure

PROJECT TREE

UMBRA / 00_STUDIO / 01_HANDBOOK / 02_UNIVERSE_BIBLE / 03_CODEX / 04_CASES / 05_PROMPT_LIBRARY / 06_BRAND / 07_MARKETING / 08_RELEASES / 09_ARCHIVE

Filename Pattern

STANDARD

CASE001_EVIDENCE_PHOTO_001_v03_MASTER.png

STANDARD	APPLICATION
CASE001	Three-digit CASE identifier
EVIDENCE_PHOTO	Asset group in uppercase snake case
001	Sequential number inside the group
v03	Working revision
MASTER	Approved state: RAW, WORK, REVIEW, MASTER or RELEASE
.png	File extension appropriate to the deliverable

Version Rules

Never overwrite a released master.

Use major revisions for changed content and minor revisions for technical corrections.

Keep editable source files outside the customer package.

Every release archive receives a version number and release date.

Changes that affect canon require a Codex and handbook review.

Backup Rule

Maintain at least three copies of active production data: working storage, independent local backup and off-device backup. The Codex, handbook, final masters and release packages are priority assets.

11. Commercial Packaging

Product Promise

The customer should understand that they are buying a curated fictional archive and a practical digital asset collection. Narrative atmosphere increases value, but usability, file quality and clear licensing create trust.

Customer Package

STANDARD	APPLICATION
START_HERE.pdf	Navigation, story premise, contents and usage guidance.
ARCHIVE_FILES	The narrative evidence in intentional browsing order.
ASSET_LIBRARY	Clean categorized assets for creative reuse.
LICENSE.pdf	Personal and commercial usage terms.
FILE_INDEX.csv or PDF	Filenames, dimensions, types and short descriptions.
BONUS	Optional wallpapers, contact sheets or alternate crops.

Marketplace Listing Assets

- Hero image that communicates the CASE premise in one glance.
- Contents overview with exact file counts and formats.
- Close-up examples showing real resolution and detail.
- Folder-structure preview to demonstrate organization.
- License summary and permitted uses.
- Story-focused preview that does not reveal the final clue.
- Clear digital-download notice and fictional-work disclosure.

Pricing Logic

Price by completeness, usability, production quality and licensing value - not by the raw number of generated images. A smaller coherent CASE with documents, navigation and commercial rights may justify a higher price than a large uncurated bundle.

Reuse Strategy

Use CASE images and documents as visual material for UMBRA Shorts.

Create smaller derivative packs only when they remain clearly related to the master CASE.

Publish selected non-spoiler assets as promotional posts or stock content where platform policy permits.

Reserve the strongest connected evidence for the complete paid archive.

Build bundles only after multiple standalone CASE products are established.

EXECUTION

12. Launch Roadmap

First 30 Days

STANDARD	APPLICATION
Days 1-3	Finalize handbook foundation, project folders and Codex templates.
Days 4-6	Write CASE-001 brief, clue map, evidence list and visual prototype.
Days 7-14	Produce primary images, documents and diagrams in controlled batches.
Days 15-18	Perform selection, corrections, typesetting and continuity review.
Days 19-22	Assemble START_HERE guide, license, index and final package.
Days 23-25	Create marketplace previews, listing copy, tags and short-form teaser.
Days 26-28	Test the customer package and publish initial listings.
Days 29-30	Record performance, buyer questions and handbook revisions before CASE-002.

CASE-001

WORKING TITLE
<i>CASE-001: The Last Elevator</i>

Premise: An ordinary residential elevator continues to serve floors removed from every official building plan. Passengers return with missing time, altered memories or objects that do not belong to them.

STANDARD	APPLICATION
Primary hook	The button panel contains a worn floor number that no resident remembers seeing.

STANDARD	APPLICATION
Primary setting	A believable late-20th-century apartment building.
Evidence media	35mm photos, CCTV stills, maintenance logs, floor plans and witness notes.
Core Codex objects	The elevator, the removed floor, one recurring passenger and one artifact.
Final unresolved question	Whether the elevator reaches a place or creates it.
Commercial angle	A complete investigation plus reusable urban-horror backgrounds and document assets.

Immediate Next Actions

☐	Create the actual UMBRA root folder structure.
☐	Create Codex record templates and reserve CASE-001 identifiers.
☐	Write the full CASE-001 creative brief.
☐	Create the CASE-001 evidence inventory and clue map.
☐	Generate and review the first three visual prototypes.
☐	Approve one art direction before full production begins.

REFERENCE

Appendix A. Working Templates

CASE Brief Template

STANDARD	APPLICATION
CASE ID	
Working title	
One-line premise	
Buyer and use case	
Primary anomaly	
Primary setting	
Evidence categories	
New Codex objects	
Existing connections	
Final unresolved question	
Required deliverables	
Release target	

Codex Record Template

STANDARD	APPLICATION
Codex ID	
Approved name	
Category	
Status	
Truth level	

STANDARD	APPLICATION
First recorded	
Observable description	
Visual continuity	
Known relationships	
Source CASE	
Prompt / method version	
Release history	

Asset Review Sheet

☐	Filename follows the approved pattern.
☐	Asset has a clear role in the CASE.
☐	Capture medium and visual treatment are plausible.
☐	No accidental generated text or unwanted marks remain.
☐	Anatomy, perspective, reflections and repeated objects have been inspected.
☐	Asset matches the approved palette and contrast range.
☐	Codex and CASE metadata are correct.
☐	Customer-facing version contains no hidden source information.
☐	Export dimensions and file format are correct.
☐	Asset is approved as MASTER or returned for revision.

Release Checklist

☐	All creative, technical and trust gates passed.
☐	Customer package tested from a clean extraction.
☐	PDFs visually rendered and inspected page by page.
☐	File index matches the actual package.
☐	Listing counts, formats and dimensions are accurate.
☐	License and fictional disclosure included.
☐	Preview images contain no misleading content.
☐	Final release archive backed up and versioned.
☐	Codex updated with all public identifiers.
☐	Post-release review date scheduled.

END OF REVISION 0.2

Next controlled document: CASE-001 Creative Brief and Evidence Plan